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turnaround. While the Dutch will be bolstered by the return of Georginio Wijnaldum, who moved to Saudi Arabia last September, the availability of midfielder Frenkie de Jong remains doubtful.

De Jong suffered his third ankle injury of the season in April, which could be a huge blow to the team's chances if he misses out.

Koeman, known for his pragmatic style, will hope the team's defensive core can come good in a tough group stage. The attack will hinge on the creativity of Cody Gakpo and Xavi Simons, who had an impressive season on loan at RB Leipzig. Wout Weghorst (above; No. 9), who had an underwhelming season in the Bundesliga, is the main striker alongside Memphis Depay.

Injuries play spoilsport

Poland also underwent a managerial change, with Fernando Santos taking over before poor results and criticism of the team's playing style led to his swift exit in September. Michal Probiez was promoted from the U-21 setup, and he led the side into the finals via the playoffs in March.

While Robert Lewandowski is coming off another high-scoring season, as seen in previous major tournaments, the striker often finds himself isolated and has to feed off scraps for service. At 36, this could be

his last chance to make an impact on the international stage.

Piotr Zielinski's creativity in the midfield will be key to unlocking Lewandowski's goal-scoring potential. Unfortunately, right-back Matty Cash misses out due to injury for Poland, which is ranked lowest in the group.

Austria enters the tournament as a dark horse, which could potentially rock the boat of the traditional favourites.

The team has achieved strong results over the last two years under Ralf Rangnick, including wins over Italy and Germany, and holding Belgium to a draw away from home.

However, injuries to captain David Alaba, goalkeeper Alexander Schlager, defender Philipp Leinhart, and central midfielder Xaver Schlager could jeopardise Das Team's chances.

The form of wingers Konrad Laimer and Marcel Sabitzer, and the goal-scoring ability of Christoph Baumgartner will be key to Austria's hopes.

Knockouts prediction:

France is the favourite to qualify for the knockouts, but there could be a three-way tussle between the rest of the pack for the second spot.

While defensive solidity is crucial in tournament football, teams will need to find ways to score goals to stay in contention to progress as one of the best third-placed teams.

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



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KYLIAN MBAPPE

It's hard to overlook Mbappe, who will be itching to open his European championship tally after failing to score in the previous edition, where his penalty miss in the shootout proved costly. Three years on, at 25, the impactful forward will want to make his mark as skipper.



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XAVI SIMONS

The PSG winger had an outstanding season in the Bundesliga during his loan spell with RB Leipzig. Xavi is an exciting attacking midfielder with excellent close control and dribbling abilities. The Dutch will count on his creativity to bail them out of the group stages.